

JUDGMENT DAY: REPLY TO WOODS

Alfred C. Snider

I admire Steve Woods as a skilled debate teacher who also treasures any opportunity to involve a wider public, and their issues, in the debate exercise. I largely agree with the content of his essay. Thus, my comments will be relatively brief.

First, Woods has continued in his direction of seeking “practical” ideas for debate students, judges, and teachers. This article is a discussion of policy debate realities and then a suggestion as to how judges and debaters can adapt to this situation in a practical and beneficial way. Woods embraces the gaming model and suggests ways to improve our practice within. I appreciate his efforts.

Second, Woods makes an important contribution when he recalls the influence of the “systems approach” provided by Brock et al. (1973). Previously debate issues had been seen in isolation, creating a situation where the affirmative had to beat back all of the attacks on its “stock issues” in order to win. Under a systems approach each stock issue would be important according to its relationship to the entire body of argumentation. Thus, an affirmative team might solve just a small part of the problem but would still present a superior “system” when compared to the status quo. It might be productive to relate the systems approach to the situation described by Woods, where issues (policy vs. critical) are seen in isolation.

Third, during the critical turn described by Woods the game goes on. He rightly identifies that as long as debaters come to the playing field they are still playing the game, even if they depart from traditional procedures. Once again, the game goes on, but different decision procedures are suggested.

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Fourth, the advocacy standard offered by Woods seems promising but currently lacks precision, something critics often seek, and usually in vain. I suggest that his work on this concept continue with an eye towards fleshing it out and providing more guidelines for its application. I think there is much that might be gained from consulting the “narrative paradigm” for communication offered by Fisher (1989) in any attempt to expand on the advocacy standard for judging competitive academic debates.

References

- Bernard B., Chesebro, J., Cragan, J., & Klumpp, J. (1973). *Public policy decision making: Systems analysis and comparative advantages debate*. New York: Harper and Row.
- Fisher, W. (1989). *Human communication as narration: Toward a philosophy of reason, value, and action*. Columbia: University of South Carolina Press.

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